

C6 Inclusive Participation

Formerly: Inclusive Brainstorm. Retitled to reflect broader scope: ensuring all voices are heard in all team interactions, not just brainstorming sessions.

Pillar	Communication	Difficulty	Level 2
Time Required	40-50 minutes	Group Size	5-12
Mode	Team facilitation	Format	In-person or remote
Prerequisites	C2 (Listening Circle) recommended	CLOVER ERA Trigger	Dominating conversations signals, fear of speaking up, information silos within the team, lack of feedback loops, feeling unheard indicators

Why This Works

THE NEUROSCIENCE

Voice equity in teams is a neurological issue, not just a fairness issue. Research by Alex Pentland at MIT found that the single best predictor of team intelligence is the equality of conversational turn-taking. When a few people dominate, the group literally becomes dumber: diverse perspectives that would improve decisions are locked inside brains that have learned it is not worth the social cost of speaking.

Quieter team members are not necessarily less capable or less interested. Their brains may be processing more deeply (introversion correlates with greater prefrontal cortex activity during processing), or their amygdala has learned through experience that speaking up carries social risk in this group. Structural interventions that create space for these voices do not just improve fairness, they improve the quality of the team's collective thinking.

The Exercise

Phase 1: The Participation Audit (10 minutes)

WHAT TO SAY

"I want each of you to think honestly about our team meetings and discussions. Three questions, write your answers privately: Who typically talks the most? Whose ideas get the most airtime? And whose perspective do you hear least often?"

Collect anonymously. Read aloud. The patterns are usually visible to everyone but never named. The act of naming them is the first step toward changing them.

Phase 2: Understanding Why (10 minutes)

WHAT TO SAY

"There are reasons some people speak more and some speak less. None of those reasons are about intelligence or commitment. Let's explore: for those who tend to speak less, what makes it harder? And for those who tend to speak more, what drives that? No judgment. Just curiosity."

Common reasons for not speaking: processing time ("I need to think before I talk and the moment passes"), status dynamics ("The senior person already said what I was thinking so it seems redundant"), past experience ("Last time I spoke up, it was dismissed"), cultural norms ("In my background, you don't interrupt or contradict").

Phase 3: Structural Solutions (15 minutes)

The team designs structural interventions. These are process changes, not appeals to behaviour:

- "Think-Write-Share": before any group discussion, give 2 minutes for individual writing. Then share in round-robin. This equalises input regardless of processing speed.
- "Speak last" rule for the manager: the manager shares their view after everyone else, not before. This prevents anchoring.
- Designated challenger: in each meeting, one person is explicitly tasked with asking "What are we missing?" or "Who hasn't weighed in?"
- Async input channel: for people who process better in writing, create a way to contribute ideas after the meeting (shared doc, Slack thread with a clear deadline).

WHAT TO SAY

"Which of these would work for us? Or is there something else that would help? The goal is not to force quiet people to talk more. The goal is to remove the barriers that prevent good ideas from reaching the group."

Phase 4: Commitment (5 minutes)

The team selects 2-3 structural changes to trial for the next month. The manager commits to modelling the "speak last" approach in the next team meeting.

Facilitation Notes

Situation	Response
A dominant contributor becomes defensive when the pattern is named	Depersonalise: "This isn't about blame. People who speak up a lot often do it because they care and they're engaged. The challenge is that it can unintentionally squeeze out other perspectives that would make our decisions better. We need both the energy and the space."
A quiet team member is visibly uncomfortable	Reframe: "There's nothing wrong with processing internally. Research shows that people who think before speaking often have the most

being identified as 'quiet'	valuable contributions. Our job is to make sure the team benefits from that thinking." Never put someone on the spot to speak more.
The team agrees to structural changes but nobody enforces them	Assign ownership. "Who's going to prompt the Think-Write-Share at our next meeting? Let's name a person and put it in the agenda." Without a specific owner, structural changes revert to old patterns within two meetings.

Signs This Is Working

Timeframe	What to Look For
During the session	Honest acknowledgment of participation patterns Quieter members contribute to the solution design The structural solutions feel practical, not aspirational
Within 2-4 weeks	Meeting dynamics visibly shift (more voices, shorter individual contributions) The manager consistently speaks last Someone uses a structural prompt: "Let's do a quick Think-Write-Share on this"
CLOVER ERA data (4-6 weeks)	'Fear of speaking up' signals decrease 'Feeling heard' indicators improve Dominating conversation signals reduce

Cross-Pillar Connections

Worksheet	Connection	Direction
C2: Listening Circle	Listening skills enable inclusive participation. C2 teaches listening; C6 creates the structural conditions for equitable speaking.	Run C2 before C6
V1: Vulnerability Circle	Speaking up in meetings requires psychological safety. V1 builds the trust that C6's structural solutions depend on.	V1 before C6 for low-trust teams
V10: Respectful Disagreement	Once more voices are heard, disagreement becomes more likely. V10 ensures that disagreement is productive.	Run C6 before V10